

Project Report of “STRONGMEN”

In the following, I will give a detailed report of the development and implementation of my game ‘STRONGMEN’. First, I explain the premise of the game and its underlying motivation. Second, I examine the theoretical background the game is based upon. Third, I outline the game’s ideal audience and its intended purpose. Fourth, I discuss the specific game mechanics I utilized. Next, I provide a description of the game’s concrete implementation. Finally, I conclude with some remarks on both conceptual difficulties and future possibilities of my game.

1. Premise and Motivation of the Game

In the beginning, the player meets the ‘eagle’ who welcomes them, inviting them to its show. The eagle, however, is not the main character of the game, as the player soon finds out. Instead, the eagle is the instructor, the guide through the game, while the player themselves assumes the role of the main actor. They are given the task of becoming a strongman, an ‘authoritarian leader, aspiring dictator, the one to rule power itself’, as the eagle puts it. Over the course of the game, the player has many choices to make in order to reach this final goal, while the eagle contextualizes these choices in a larger historical framework by comparing the players decisions with the actions of previous strongmen. Hence, the player does not simply learn how to become a strongmen, but instead familiarizes themselves with the common playbook used – knowingly or unknowingly – by all of them.

To the informed player – though they are not the target audience – the choices of the game are eerily similar to contemporary political events in the USA. Though never mentioned by name, almost all of the options available to the player are directly motivated by actions taken either by Trump himself or his administration. The intention, though, is not to simply list all the criticisms I or others might direct against the Trump administration. Instead, the game is meant to help the player understand both the complexities of the current political situation and its historical context. It is hence meant to motivate the player to seek additional information and formulate their own opinion. However, the game cannot provide a complete guide, nor can it be unbiased.

Though it is not meant to lead the player to one specific conclusion, it calls out authoritarian politics and the tools that have been used again and again to undermine democratic governments. Note that the last statement is not based on my own theory, but originates from Ruth Ben-Ghiat and her book, ‘Strongmen – Mussolini to the Present’, which I heavily rely on for my theoretical background.

2. Theoretical Background

Ruth Ben-Ghiat is professor of history and Italian studies at the university of New York, specializing in fascism and authoritarian leaders. In her 2020 book, ‘Strongmen – Mussolini to the Present’, she draws a direct line from early 20th-century dictators like Mussolini, Hitler, and Franco, through those of the late 20th century – such as Pinochet, Mobutu, and Gaddafi – to today’s autocratic leaders, including Erdogan, Orbán, Putin, and Trump.

The book focuses on democratic governments that fall victim to authoritarian leaders, called ‘strongmen’, with Ben-Ghiat arguing that such developments, and especially the leaders behind them, share a number of common characteristics. While some tactics may have been adjusted to fit changing circumstances, Ben-Ghiat identifies recurring patterns in the behavior of such strongmen. These range from propagating myths, such as a ‘glorious past,’ a ‘victimized nation,’ ‘white replacement,’ or an ‘immigrant invasion,’ to undermining institutions like the legal system, independent press, and universities. Other hallmarks include anti-left, anti-feminist, and anti-LGBTQ rhetoric, as well as displays of wealth, military power, and hypermasculinity. However, Ben-Ghiat does not argue that history repeats itself. Instead, she uses these common patterns to highlight both how to identify authoritarian tactics and how to recognize an aspiring strongman – and how to resist one that has already seized power. Her book not only highlights the strongmen’s shared tools, maneuvers, and behaviors, but also their downfalls, which follow similar patterns too.

Note that, as mentioned above, Ben-Ghiat’s book was published in 2020. Hence, while any examples used for comparison to other authoritarian leaders are taken from her book, any actual game choices, i.e., the ones adapting actions of Trump or his

administration, are taken from recent politics. As these are subject to change, it is possible that either specific options or the game in its entirety have become obsolete by the time of reading.

3. Target Audience

While the game is meant to promote political education in general, it is intended to be used by late middle school and high school classes. One possible use case is as follows: The game could be integrated into a broader lesson focused on history and political education. After playing the game, students are divided into groups, with each group assigned to research a contemporary decision or historical context depicted in the game. Each group then presents their findings to the class, followed by a final group discussion. This approach allows students to practice both their research and critical thinking skills, while also forming their own opinions based on the information gathered during the lesson. Hence, the game could serve as a fun and accessible entry point into the complex topic of authoritarian politics.

4. Game Mechanics

The game incorporates several key game mechanics. Most notably, it features meaningful choices that influence two core scores – ‘Ego’ and ‘Resistance’ – as well as the progression of the gameplay. After the introduction, the next three rounds consist of character building. The player selects a strength, a weakness, and a cause, each of which affects elements of the plot. Additionally, the selected strength and weakness directly impact how the two scores are calculated during the game.

5. Implementation

The game consists of an introduction, three rounds of character building, seven rounds of actual gameplay and an end sequence. Both the character building and the early choices of the game affect the gameplay as well and the final outcome. There are two scores which define the outcome of the game, 'Ego' and 'Resistance'.

Depending on the choices the player makes, there are three possible outcomes. If

Each choice the player makes has one or two corresponding weights that are added to or subtracted from the value of the scores, with there being a total of 18 weights in the game. Additionally, there are two multipliers, one for Ego and one for Resistance, that are applied whenever their respective score is impacted by a decision. Their concrete numerical values dependent on the choices made during the character building section.

5.1. Parameter Finetuning

The game has two scores that

5.2. Character Design

At the start of the game, the player meets the 'eagle' who welcomes them and invites them to join them on its stage.

5.3. Practical Implementation

5.4. Feedback and Modifications

6. Final Remarks

8.9. 14:00 - 16:00